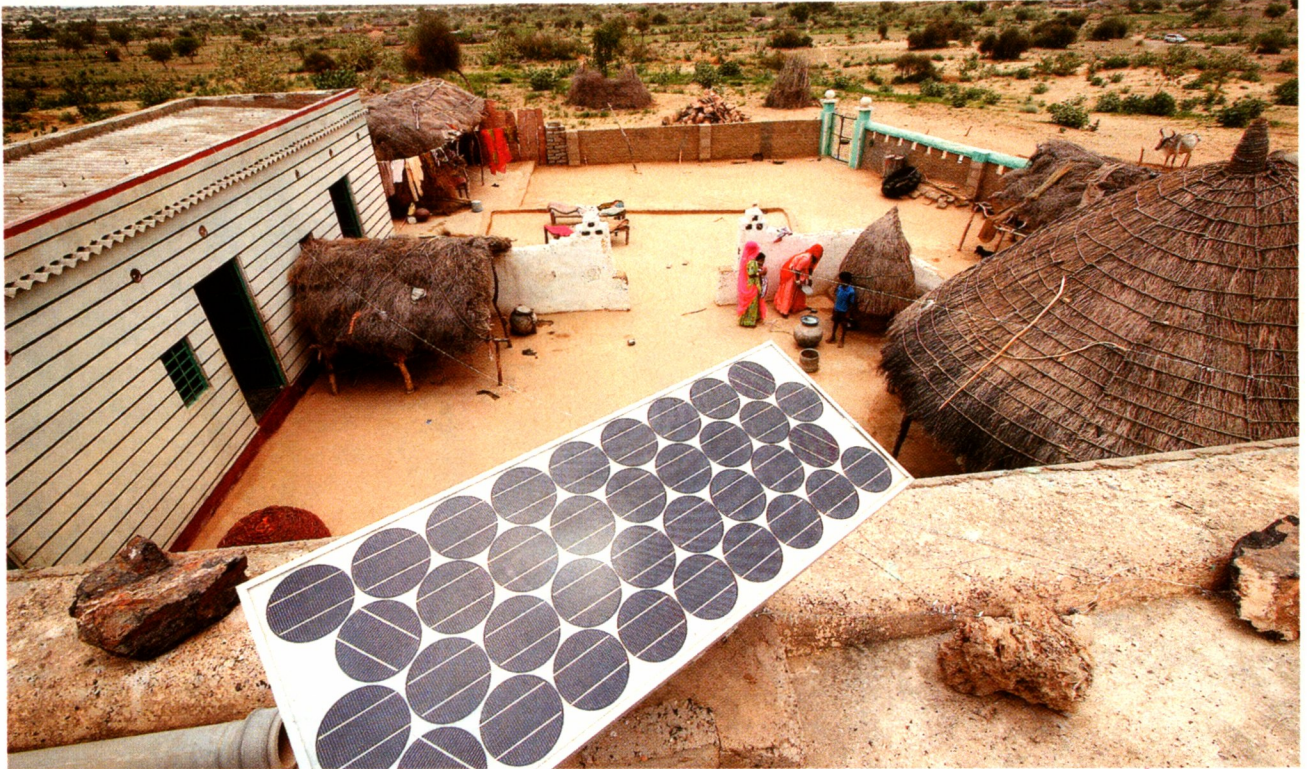




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Power citadel: The government needs to provide incentives for energy efficiency

ally in 1992 clearly requires the developed countries to take the first steps in mitigation. Sadly, the developed world has done very little in reducing their own emissions and despite India's low per capita emissions, they continue to harp on India, adopting restrictions purely by virtue of its size. It is, therefore, logical and totally justifiable for India not to succumb to these pressures from the developed nations. However, there are other considerations which require this country to come up with a totally different approach in development, which is distinctly different from what has been practiced in some of the most prosperous countries in the world. Just like Japan treated the energy crises of 1973-74 and 1979-80 as an opportunity, India is in a similar position to gain competitive advantage in a world whose future rests on low carbon technologies, products and processes. If India's policy on climate change were to bring about a rapid reduction of carbon intensity in every major activity, we would certainly become leaders in the global market and attain a high level of economic achievement. But this would require a universal change of mindsets and the public shunning the western image of a consumptive and environmentally insensitive lifestyle.

It is in this respect that the Prime Minister's National Action Plan on Climate Change deserves serious consideration and action at all levels for operationalising the vision on which it is based. The opportunity for using solar energy on a large scale in this country is immense and unlimited. Right from solar water heating to power generation using solar thermal technologies, India can within a period of 10 years emerge as a leader in a range of technologies and equipment to exploit the abundance of energy from the sun. Given the rapid rate at which the industrial sector is growing, there is also a need to not only set up new capacity which is energy efficient, but also retrofit existing processes and equipment with energy efficient devices and technologies. The Government can provide both physical incentives as well as regulatory mechanisms by which this can be achieved on a large scale. But, there would neither be support for these measures nor participation by the public unless a reorientation of attitudes can be brought about urgently to create a respect for nature and its bounty of resources. The time for such a change is right now.

The author is the chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change.